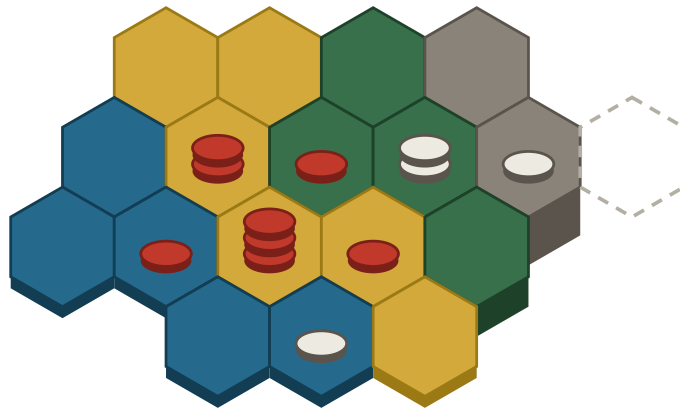


# Blink

*Climbing the ladder of civilization*

2-4 PLAYERS    60-120 MINUTES    TOBY SIKO



## Start here

Each round you play a **meld** — a small combination of cards. The meld competes for the trick, and then every card in it becomes something: a settler, a new tile, an attack — or a coin. Win the trick and you act first, with every card you played still yours to spend; match the winner's count and lose, and one of yours is set aside. Come last and you pocket a coin.

- 1 **Card phase.** Everyone plays a meld. The highest total wins the trick.
- 2 **Map phase.** In initiative order, spend your meld — each card settles a unit, explores a new tile, attacks a rival, or is cashed for gold. Alongside the cards you have your free actions: your band's free moves, and gold shuffled between food, fortresses and research.
- 3 **Grow, and pay for it.** Units leave your board in tiers. Each tier you empty pays you a one-off ascension reward, lets you play a bigger meld and move further — and raises the gold your people cost to feed.

The game ends when someone places their last unit or the market thins to its last layer. Most points wins: one per unit on the map, plus your victory row, plus terrain majorities.

## 01 The idea

In Blink, the cards you play do two things at once. They compete for the trick, and they are the budget your civilization spends. A pair is two things done; a run of four is four. You never choose a move separately from the cards — the meld is the budget.

Winning the trick lets you act first, and every card you played still reaches the map. The player who came last takes a coin. So a strong meld buys tempo, but growth has a cost: the more ground you hold, the more it takes to feed, and feeding comes due whether or not you won.

Behind every card sits one plain question: **is it people, or is it gold?** Spent on the map, a card settles a unit, opens new ground or strikes a rival — always on terrain matching its suit. Cashed, it is a coin, and coins buy food, fortresses and research. Gold is tight, and winning play cashes cards constantly. The player who reads when a hand is people and when it is money — and when to spend a trick rather than win it — comes out ahead.

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## 02 Components

- **80 civilization cards** — four suits (Plains, Forest, Ocean, Mountain), ranks 1–20
- **60 terrain tiles** — 15 each of Plains, Forest, Ocean and Mountain
- **80 population units** — 20 in each of four player colours
- **4 player boards** — each with a **reserve** of five tiers, a **gold area**, and a **victory row** of five slots
- **40 gold coins** — if you run out, treat the supply as unlimited
- **4 initiative dice** — use one per player



The four terrains at a glance. Defended ground is shown taller — a visual reminder of its attack cost, nothing more. The numbers on the table are the rules.

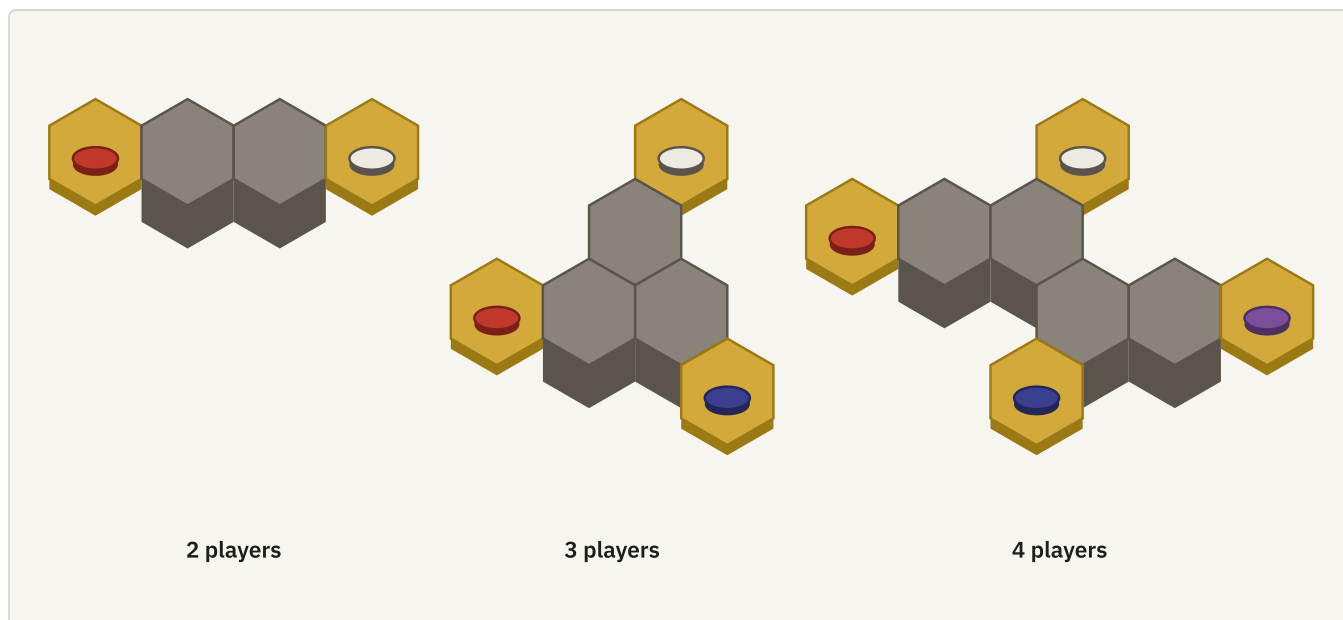
# Setup

- 1
- Split the cards.** Divide the 80 cards into a **starting deck** and an **upgrade deck** by rank, according to the player count.

| PLAYERS | STARTING DECK | UPGRADE DECK |
|---------|---------------|--------------|
| 2       | ranks 6–10    | ranks 11–20  |
| 3       | ranks 3–10 †  | ranks 11–20  |
| 4       | ranks 1–10    | ranks 11–20  |

† **Three-player balance.** Ranks 3–10 give 32 starting cards for 30 dealt. Draw **two of the four rank-3 cards at random** and keep them; return the other two to the box. The upgrade deck is the full **ranks 11–20 at every player count** — the tier rank caps only mean something if the market reaches above them.

- 2
- Draft your hand.** Deal 10 starting-deck cards to each player. Keep 4 and pass 6 clockwise; keep 6 and pass 4; keep 8 and pass 2; keep the last 2. You end with a fixed hand of **ten cards**.
- 3
- Take a board.** Fill all five tiers with your 20 units — 2, 3, 5, 5, 5 from the top. Place the **ascension coins** on their printed spots: 1 on Settlement, 2 on Kingdom, 3 on Empire, 4 on Civilization. Your meld limit starts at **2**.
- 4
- Lay the starting map.** Build the layout shown for your player count, then each player places one unit from their top band on their own Plains tile. Whatever the count, the map obeys the same three rules:
- **one Mountain per player**, in a single block in the middle;
  - **one Plains per player** around it, each touching exactly one Mountain;
  - every start exactly **three tiles** from every other.
- Three is not decoration. A card only acts next to your civilization, so in the opening rounds nobody can reach a rival's homeland at all. Long before homelands are in danger, the Mountains become the contested ground — each holds one unit and costs 2 gold a card to take — so the fight for the middle comes first.
- 5
- Tile supply.** Sort the remaining tiles into four open piles by terrain, where everyone can see and reach them. There is no bag and nothing is hidden: any tile may be taken at any time until that terrain runs out.
- 6
- Upgrade deck and market.** Shuffle **all advanced cards together** into one face-down deck — **ranks 11–20, whatever the player count**. Deal **nine face up in a 3 × 3 grid** beside it — that is the market (§10). Leave a clear space next to it for the **shared pile**: it starts empty, and fills with the cards losing melds discard (§04).
- 7
- First player.** Choose a start player. They take initiative die “1”.



The starting layouts. One Mountain per player forms the block in the middle; one Plains per player sits around it, each touching exactly one Mountain, and every start is three tiles from every other. Nobody opens with cheaper access to the high ground, and nobody can be reached in the first rounds.

## 04 The round

Every round has two halves. First everyone plays cards. Then everyone spends those same cards, in the order the cards decided.

Your board holds your 20 units in **five tiers** — 2, then 3, then 5, then 5, then a final 5 — and you always take units from the **topmost tier that still holds any**. That tier is your current tier, and it prints the four numbers that govern your game: the size of meld you may play, the free moves you get each turn, the gold your people cost to feed, and the highest card rank you may buy from the market.

| TIER         | UNITS | MELD LIMIT | FREE MOVES | FOOD PER RECYCLE | RANK CAP |
|--------------|-------|------------|------------|------------------|----------|
| Tribe        | 2     | 2          | 1          | free             | 12       |
| Settlement   | 3     | 3          | 2          | 1                | 14       |
| Kingdom      | 5     | 4          | 3          | 2                | 16       |
| Empire       | 5     | 5          | 4          | 3                | 18       |
| Civilization | 5     | 6          | 5          | 4                | 20       |

Read all four off the topmost tier that still holds units — one rule, no counting, and **nothing cumulative**: you owe the coins on that tier and no others. Empty a tier and every number steps up together: the expansion that buys you a bigger meld and a longer stride is the same expansion that sends you the bill. Melds never exceed six; placing the last unit of the Civilization tier ends the game (§11).

Ascension

Each tier below the first has a **coin printed on your board** at setup. The first time you reach that tier – the moment the tier above it empties – take those coins from your board into your reserve.

| REACHING         | SETTLEMENT | KINGDOM | EMPIRE | CIVILIZATION |
|------------------|------------|---------|--------|--------------|
| Ascension reward | 1          | 2       | 3      | 4            |

First time only. Ground you later lose does not put the coins back, and falling to a lower tier does not let you claim them twice.

RESERVE

empty from the top band down

2

cards

Tribe

2 units

3

cards

Settlement

3 units

4

cards

Kingdom

5 units

5

cards

Empire

5 units

6

cards

Civilization

5 units

FOOD

MOVES

free

1

2

3

4

5

Each recycle your people eat your current tier's coins only – food is not cumulative.

Free moves refresh every turn.

GOLD

VICTORY ROW

The reserve empties from the top band down. Each tier you clear raises the meld you may play – 2, 3, 4, 5, 6 – and your free moves – 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 – pays a one-off ascension coin, and moves you onto a costlier row. You always pay only the row you are on. Here Tribe is spent and Settlement half-emptied: melds of three, two free moves, one food owed each recycle.

Declare

Before a single card is played, each player may spend one card from their victory row on effect **A** (\$10). Declare together on a count of three, or in turn order from the leader – whichever your table prefers, so long as it happens *before any meld is on the table*.

You are committing blind. You do not know what anyone is about to play, only what is in your own hand – which is the whole point: A is a bet, not an answer.

Only **A** is declared here. **B** is used in your own map phase and **C** at any moment, so neither needs announcing now. Most rounds nobody declares anything and the step takes a second.

## Card phase

- ① The leader plays a meld from their hand — anything from a single card up to their current **meld size limit**, read off their board. You begin the game able to play two cards at a time.
- ② Clockwise, every other player plays a meld of their own, from one card up to their own limit. You may not pass, and you never have to follow what was led.
- ③ The **highest total wins** the trick: add up the ranks of the cards in each meld. A single 20 is worth more than three 6s. If two totals are equal, the meld with **more cards** wins; if they are still level, compare their **highest card**, then second-highest, and so on. If two melds are still identical, the one played **earlier** wins. There are never ties after this.
- ④ Set the initiative dice: winner to 1, then the rest in that same order.

## Map phase

In initiative order, each player spends their meld — card by card, in any order, each card resolved fully before the next (§06) — and takes their free actions (§07), woven between the cards however they like. Finish your whole turn before the next player begins.

**The trick winner spends every card of their meld.** So does everyone who played fewer cards than the winner. Cashing a card for gold is always your own choice, never a penalty (§06).

The round then settles two ways:

- **Match the winner's card count and lose, and one of your played cards is set aside.** You choose which. It is not spent on the map — instead it pays you **1 gold** and goes face down onto the **shared pile** (§09), where it becomes part of somebody's next hand. Play as many cards as the winner and you must give one up; play *fewer* and nothing happens, because you are already below the winner's count.
- **The player whose meld ranked last takes 1 gold.** Only that one player, whatever the player count. If the last-ranked player also matched the winner's count, they take both coins.

Nothing is docked from your hand, and there is no winner's bonus card: the winner's advantage is that they act first and that every card they played reaches the map.

A meld you have resolved goes face up into your **personal discard**, in front of you. That pile is not lost — it becomes your next hand when your current hand runs out (§09). The one card that leaves your economy for good is the card you set aside: it goes to the shared pile, and the next player to run out of cards may well draw it.

When all players have finished, hand the lead to the trick winner and begin a new round.

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## 05 Melds

One rule, and it replaces every meld type Blink used to have.

## THE MELD RULE

A meld is **any cards whose ranks form an unbroken run** — every rank from your lowest to your highest must be present. **How many cards you hold of each rank does not matter, and suits do not matter at all.** One card is always a legal meld.

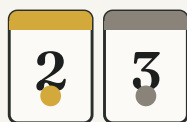
| CARDS     | LEGAL? | WHY                                    |
|-----------|--------|----------------------------------------|
| 2         | yes    | a single card is a run of one          |
| 2 2       | yes    | one rank, no gap possible              |
| 2 3       | yes    | 2 then 3, unbroken                     |
| 2 3 3 4 4 | yes    | 2, 3, 4 all present — doubles are free |
| 2 2 4 4   | no     | nothing at rank 3 — the run is broken  |



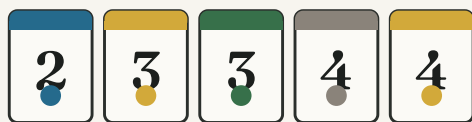
✓ one card is always a run



✓ one rank, doubled



✓ 2 then 3



✓ 2, 3, 4 all present — doubles are free



✗ nothing at rank 3 — the run is broken

The whole rule in five rows. Every rank between your lowest and your highest must be present; how many of each you hold does not matter, and suits are irrelevant at this stage. Only the last row is illegal, and only because nothing sits at rank 3.

So the old vocabulary is gone. There is no straight, no set, no full house — only runs with any number of duplicates. A pair is a run of one rank; a straight is a run with no duplicates; everything between them is now legal too.

Your **meld limit** is the ceiling on how many cards you may play, never a quota: Tribe 2, Settlement 3, Kingdom 4, Empire 5, Civilization 6. Suits still matter enormously — but only later, when each card is spent on terrain

matching its suit (§06).

#### LOSING THE TRICK COSTS YOU ALMOST NOTHING

Play *fewer* cards than the winner and every one of them still reaches the map; if your meld came last, it also pays you a coin. The only players who give anything up are those who **matched the winner's card count** and lost, and even they are paid a gold for the card (§04). Playing a single on purpose is a real line, not a failure — matching the winner and losing is the one thing that costs.

## 06 Spending your meld

Take each card of your meld in turn — **in any order you like** — and do *one* of four things with it. Each card resolves fully before the next, on the map as the last card left it: a tile you lay with one card can be settled by the next.

Two rules govern every card. Nothing else constrains it.

- 1 **Reach.** A card acts on a single cell **next to your civilization**: a tile you occupy, or a tile or empty space adjacent to one you occupy. Cards of the same meld need not land near each other — one can grow a border while another strikes across the map.
- 2 **Suit matches terrain.** The cell's terrain matches the card's suit — a Forest card acts on Forest, an Ocean card on Ocean. This holds for every one of the four uses below except taking gold.

#### IF YOU ARE SWEEPED OFF THE MAP

Losing your last unit does not end your game. While you have **no units on the map** at the start of your map phase, your cards are **exempt from the reach rule**: they act on any unoccupied tile matching their suit, anywhere on the map. You re-found your civilization and carry on.

## Settle

Put one unit from your board's reserve on the cell — always the topmost band that still holds any. One card, one unit. Drawing down the reserve is how your civilization gets bigger — and how the game ends (§11).

You may stack units on a tile up to that terrain's population limit — three on Plains, two in Forest, one on Ocean or Mountain.

## Explore

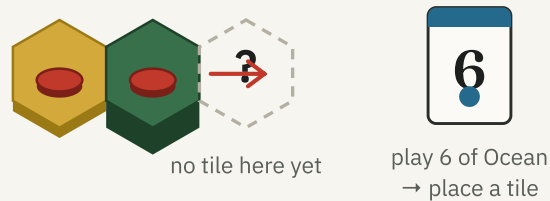
If the cell is an **empty space** beside your civilization, place a tile there from the open supply instead of placing a unit. The tile must match the card's suit. No unit goes down — settle it with a later card, or leave it as open ground.

The world grows compact, and one rule keeps it that way: **a new tile must touch at least two tiles already on the map**. Among the spaces that qualify, your reach decides which you may take.

Two edges, always. A tile touching only one existing tile is the first plank of a bridge into open table, and Blink has no bridges: every new tile is wedged into the mass, so the map grows as a single body you can still reach across. Two is also the most the rule can safely ask — any two neighbouring tiles leave a space touching them both, so there is always somewhere legal to explore. Ask for three and the map could grow into a shape it can never grow out of.



The supply is open, so there is never any searching: take the tile you need. If that terrain has **run out** — all fifteen are already on the map — the card takes gold instead.

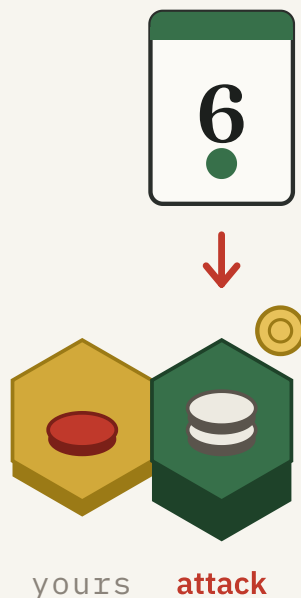


Exploring lays new ground beside your civilization. The tile matches the suit of the card and must touch at least two existing tiles — and the very next card may settle it.

## Attack

When the cell is a tile a rival occupies, you cannot settle there. Instead, spending that card **removes one of the rival's units** from the tile, back to their board. Your own unit is **not** placed — the card is spent on the attack, and the unit you would have settled stays in your reserve.

So taking a contested tile is patient work: one card clears one defender, and only once the tile is empty can a later card settle it. A stack of rivals must be worn down over more than one turn.



**One defender removed — your unit stays in reserve.**

Attacking is not moving a unit across the map. A card spent on a rival tile removes one defender — your own unit never leaves your reserve. Clearing a stack takes as many cards as there are defenders.

High ground is not safer, only dearer. **Each card you spend attacking** pays the terrain's price first — so clearing a two-unit Forest with two cards costs 2 gold, not 1. If you cannot pay, you cannot attack that cell; the card does something else, or takes gold.

| ATTACKING INTO                                                                             | COST PER CARD | CARDS TO CLEAR A FULL STACK |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------|-----------------------------|
|  Plains   | free          | 3                           |
|  Ocean    | free          | 1                           |
|  Forest   | 1 gold        | 2                           |
|  Mountain | 2 gold        | 1                           |

To capture ground, empty it first and settle it after — which always takes more than one round.

## Take gold

Instead of using a card on the map, take **1 gold**. Any card, any number of them — a whole meld can be cashed. This is not a fallback for cards that found no terrain: gold is tight, it buys food, fortresses and research (§07), and winning play turns cards into coins constantly. Every card asks the same question — people, or gold?

## 07 Free actions

Besides the cards, your map phase carries three kinds of free action. They cost no card, and you may weave them between your card plays in any order.

### Free moves

Your current tier prints your free moves — **Tribe 1, Settlement 2, Kingdom 3, Empire 4, Civilization 5** — and you may use up to that many each map phase. Each move takes one of your units:

- **By land** — move a unit any distance **across tiles occupied by your units**, stepping off at the end onto an adjacent free tile with room under its population limit. Your network carries the traveller; the last step may leave it.
- **By sea** — move a unit standing on Ocean across **unoccupied Ocean**, as far as the open water reaches, ending on an empty Ocean tile.

Movement is never an attack: you may not move onto or through a rival, and moving onto a tile is only possible while it has room. You may empty a tile by moving its last unit away — splitting your civilization in two is allowed. An empty tile is nobody's, and your neighbours will notice. Because Ocean holds only one unit, the sea is a road rather than a place to live.

## The water advantage

**The first time each turn that you move by sea**, you may immediately **explore one tile of any terrain you like** — free, and not tied to any card's suit. The new tile must touch at least two tiles already on the map, as every explore must (§06) — but it does **not** have to be within your reach. Lay it anywhere the map will legally take it.

That is the whole difference between a voyage and a card. A card acts beside your own civilization; a ship brings back news of ground you have never stood on. The sea is how a civilization finds land it had no card for — and sometimes finds it on somebody else's doorstep. Once per turn, however many sea moves your tier allows.

#### A SEA MOVE STARTS ON THE WATER

Read the second bullet above literally: a sea move is made by *a unit standing on Ocean*. Stepping onto an empty Ocean tile **from land** is an ordinary land move — it is how you reach the water, and it pays nothing.

So the advantage costs two moves: one to put a unit out to sea, one to sail it. A **Tribe has only one free move** and cannot do both in the same turn — it must leave a unit on the water and collect the tile next turn. Getting a boat out early is an investment, and that is the point: the ocean pays the civilizations that have already committed to it.

Touch-two still holds — §06 has no bridges, and a voyage does not get to build one. If the map has no legal space at all, or the terrain you want has run out, the advantage is simply **not spent**: sail again later in the same turn and you may still take it.

## Reallocate your gold

Your coins live in four places, and during your own map phase you may move them freely between the first three:

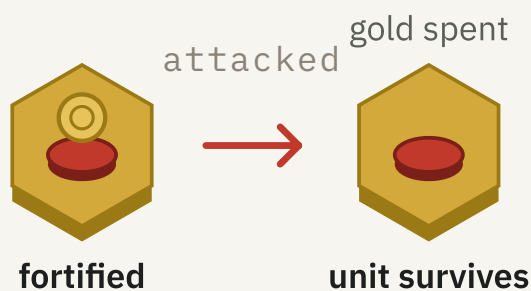
- **Reserve** — the gold area on your board. Liquid, uncommitted.
- **Food** — coins on your current band's food slots (§09). This is the supply your people will eat at the next recycle.
- **Fortifications** — coins standing on your units on the map (below).
- **Research** — gold spent on upgrades (§10). Spending is one way: a coin given to research is gone.

Reallocation is free and unlimited on your own turn. Between your turns the coins stand where you left them — and that is when they matter: a fortification only protects while the coin is on the unit, and your food only counts if it is on the slots when your hand recycles.

## Fortifying

A coin on one of your units means that unit **cannot be removed by an attack**: the attack takes the gold to the supply instead, and both units survive. One coin per unit, never two. The coin is lost to the supply the moment the unit is disturbed in any way — attacked, moved, or stacked onto.

You cannot fortify in response to an attack — attacks happen on someone else's turn, and by then it is too late. A fortification is a read on your neighbours, paid for in advance.



Gold on a unit buys it exactly one escape. Move that unit, stack onto it, or disturb it in any way, and the gold is lost to the supply.

## One victory card

Once per map phase you may spend a card from your victory row on its **B** effect (§10) — new ground founded beyond your meld: a tile or two from the supply, a unit from your reserve on each, and a fortification coin on each of those units from the general supply. It explores, so touch-two and your reach both apply. Effects A and C have their own moments; B is the only one tied to your turn, and it is **at most one per turn**.

## 08 Terrain

| TERRAIN                                                                                      | HOLDS | COSTS TO ATTACK |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------|-----------------|
|  Plains   | 3     | free            |
|  Ocean    | 1     | free            |
|  Forest   | 2     | 1 gold          |
|  Mountain | 1     | 2 gold          |

These values are fixed — nothing in the game ever modifies them. As a visual aid, defended terrain is moulded taller: Forest stands two layers, Mountain three, so a glance at the map recalls the attack cost without looking anything up.

The supply holds the four terrains in **equal numbers — 15 each**. That mirrors the deck, where every suit appears at every rank. No terrain is scarce, and no card in your hand is worth more than another because the ground it needs is rarer. What a terrain is worth is set by how many units it holds and what it costs to take — never by how much of it exists.

## 09 Feeding and refilling

You play with a hand of **ten cards**. Cards leave it for good in two ways — **set aside** when you match the winner's count and lose, which sends a card you already played to the shared pile (§04), and **retired** to your victory row when you research (§10) — so the hand is topped back up rather than merely recycled.

The moment you play your **last hand card**, your hand **recycles** — immediately, in the middle of your turn, before you do anything else. Do not wait for the end of the turn: pick everything back up straight away, and you still have your full map phase and your research in front of you.

- ① **Feed your population** (below).
- ② **Take back everything you have played** — your whole personal discard.
- ③ **Draw from the shared pile** until you hold ten again. The shared pile is the face-down stack in the middle of the table, beside the market; it starts the game empty and holds the cards *set aside* by melds that matched the winner and lost (§04). Shuffle it before drawing if it has not been shuffled since cards were added.

Then carry on with your turn. Because the refill is immediate, playing your whole hand never costs you your research — you simply pick up ten fresh cards and retire one of those instead.

So your ten are no longer the same ten all game. Cards you lose flow into the shared pile, and cards other players lost flow back to you. A hand you drafted carefully will drift, and what it drifts toward is whatever the table has been throwing away.

Every player refills to exactly ten and every discarded card goes to the same pile, so the pile always holds enough. If it is ever empty when you must draw, you are already holding ten.

Your current tier prints its **food slots** — **Tribe none, Settlement 1, Kingdom 2, Empire 3, Civilization 4** — and the coins standing on them are your food supply. When your hand recycles, your people **eat the supply**: the coins on your slots go back to the general supply, and the meal is paid. Food is **not cumulative** — you feed the band you are on and no others.

If the slots are short — the food is not there when the recycle comes — return **one unit from the map to your board for each missing coin**. The debt is then settled; you never owe food into the next recycle. Coins reach the slots by reallocation on your own turn (§07): a well-run civilization sets the table before the harvest, and everyone can see whose slots are standing empty.

**You choose which units go.** There is no rule forcing you to give up your weakest or least defended ground first. A unit removed this way loses any fortification coin standing on it, and that gold returns to the supply.

A unit that comes back — starved off the map, or removed by an attack — goes into the **lowest band that still has a free slot**: the band you emptied most recently. Only once that band is full again does the one above it begin to refill. Losing ground walks your limit back down *one step at a time*, and never drops you straight to the beginning.

#### THE PRESSURE

The very expansion that lets you play a bigger meld is what sends you the bill: every band you clear moves you onto a costlier row, up to three gold a recycle at Empire. Gold buys research, fortifications, attacks on defended terrain, and food, and there is never enough for all four. A civilization that expands faster than it earns will starve back down — and shrink its own melds doing it. Losing a trick pays you a gold per unused card, so falling behind quietly helps you feed; racing ahead does not.

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## 10 Research and the market

All advanced cards are shuffled together into a single face-down **upgrade deck**. Nine of them lie face up beside it in a **3 × 3 grid** — the market.

**Up to twice per turn**, during your map phase, you may research. The **first research of a turn costs 1 gold, the second costs 2** — everything else about them is identical:

- ① **Draw the top card** of the upgrade deck and place it face up on the grid position showing the **highest rank**, covering it. If two positions tie, take the leftmost. The covered card is out of reach until the one on top of it is taken. Nobody chooses this — the tallest idea on the market is always the one buried next.
- ② **Retire the lowest-ranked card in your hand** into your **victory row**. If you hold several of that rank, choose which suit to give up. It leaves play for the rest of the game — but it scores (§11). Cards you have already played to the table are spent: they cannot be retired.
- ③ **Pay the price** — 1 gold the first time this turn, 2 the second — and take **any visible market card whose rank is at or below your tier's rank cap** — Tribe 12, Settlement 14, Kingdom 16, Empire 18, Civilization 20. It goes **straight into your hand** — ready to play next round, not waiting on your next recycle.
- ④ **Refill** any of the nine grid positions left empty from the top of the deck. Once the deck is empty, positions stay empty and the market begins to thin — which is what ends the game (§11).

#### THE CAP IS A BUYING RULE, NOT A HOLDING RULE

Your rank cap only applies at the moment you take a card from the market. A card already in your hand, your discard or your victory row is yours to keep and use however it arrived — a low tier cannot reach the top of the market, but it is never forced to give up what it has.

#### YOUR WORST CARD, NOT YOUR BEST

Research replaces the weakest idea you hold with a stronger one: the card that leaves is always your lowest. So the victory row is a record of what your civilization *outgrew*, and it grows with you — early on it takes 3s and 4s, and by the late game your lowest card may be a 12.

A high card *can* still reach the row — but only by being lived with. Hold it while you play the rest of your hand down, and eventually it is the lowest thing you have. What you cannot do is buy a 17 and park it straight into the row: everything in there was once the worst card you owned.

Waiting for that is a thinner edge than it looks. Every research you skip is a card the row never gets, and each of those is worth a point on its own before any rank is counted — so a civilization that researches whenever it can afford to generally out-scores one that waits for the perfect card to fall.

Your victory row holds at most **five cards**. To add a sixth, first discard one of the five permanently — a card discarded this way is gone, and never scores.

## Spending a victory card

Every card carries **three printed effects**, and a card in your victory row may be spent on **exactly one** of them. The card is then removed from the game — your row shrinks, and your end score with it. The three options are always the same three kinds, growing with the card's rank:

| RANK  | A • CARD PHASE                            | B • MAP PHASE                                                                    | C • ANY TIME  |
|-------|-------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------|
| 1–5   | Add this card's <b>rank</b> to your total | <b>Found a colony</b> — 1 new tile of this suit, 1 unit, fortified               | <b>2</b> gold |
| 6–10  | Add its <b>rank</b> , and <b>win ties</b> | <b>Found a distant colony</b> — as above, up to 2 tiles out                      | <b>3</b> gold |
| 11–15 | Add this card's <b>rank</b> to your total | <b>Open a frontier</b> — 2 new tiles, 1 unit on one of them, fortified           | <b>4</b> gold |
| 16–20 | Add its <b>rank</b> , and <b>win ties</b> | <b>Two colonies</b> — 2 new tiles of any terrain, 1 unit on each, both fortified | <b>5</b> gold |

**A** is declared in the *declare step* at the top of the round, before any meld is played (§04) — blind, knowing only your own hand. Its bonus counts only toward winning the trick, never toward extra spending on the map; if two players both declare an effect that wins ties, the one who spent the **higher-ranked card** takes the trick. **B** is used during your own map phase, **at most once per turn** (§07), when you can already see the board. It finds ground: lay the new tile or tiles from the supply, settle a unit from your reserve on each one the card provides for, and fortify each of those units with a coin **from the general supply** — that gold is not yours and never was. Every tile it lays is an *explore*, so §06 applies in full: the space must touch at least two tiles already on the map and lie **within your reach**. The 6–10 band is the one exception, and the only reason to prefer it: its colony may sit **up to two tiles out**. **C** may be taken at any moment, even mid-payment when feeding falls short.

#### ONE ROW, THREE APPETITES

The same five slots are your *score*, your *war chest* and your *trick insurance*. High cards score best in the centre slot — and their effects are also the strongest, so the card you most want to keep is the card you most want to spend. That tension is the point.

## A worked example

Three players — **Ada**, **Bex** and **Cy** — sit down to their first game. This walks their setup and one full round, so you can watch every rule fire in order.

### Setting up

With three players, the **starting deck** is ranks 3–10 and the **upgrade deck** ranks 11–20, shuffled together. They deal ten cards apiece and draft — keep four and pass the rest, then keep six, keep eight, keep all ten — until each holds a fixed hand of ten.

Each takes a board and loads all five tiers with twenty units, and sets their ascension coins on the printed spots. They lay the three-player starting map — three Mountains in a triangle with a Plains beyond each outer face, every start three tiles from the others — and each puts one unit on a Plains tile of their own. The remaining tiles are sorted into four open piles by terrain. Finally they sort the advanced cards into **four suit decks**, lowest rank on top, and reveal the top of each: a four-card market showing 11 of Plains, 11 of Forest, 11 of Ocean, 11 of Mountain. Ada is chosen to start and takes initiative die “1”.



## The card phase

Everyone's board is full, so the meld limit is **2** for all three. Ada leads.

- **Ada** plays **5 of Plains + 6 of Plains** — the run 5-6.
- **Bex** plays **8 of Mountain + 8 of Ocean** — the run 8, doubled. Suits are irrelevant to the meld.
- **Cy** plays a single **4 of Mountain**.

Now the trick resolves: **highest total wins**. Bex played 8 + 8 for **16**; Ada played 5 + 6 for **11**; Cy played a single 4 for **4**. **Bex wins the trick** and takes initiative die 1 — she will lead next round. Ada, next best, takes die 2; Cy takes die 3.

Note what Cy could have done: a single 17 would have beaten both of them on its own. Under a total, one big card is a play, not a waste.

Because **Ada matched Bex's two cards and lost**, one of the two cards she played is **set aside**: it pays her 1 gold and goes to the shared pile instead of acting on the map. She picks which. Cy played only one — fewer than the winner — so he gives up nothing, and as the last-ranked meld he takes **1 gold**.

## The map phase

Bex spends both her cards; Ada spends the one she kept; Cy spends his single. They act in initiative order.

- **Bex** (2 cards). Only Plains and Mountain exist at setup, so her **Mountain** card is the one that can settle: the Mountain beside her start is adjacent to her homeland — in reach — and she **settles** it, taking a unit from her top band. Mountain holds one, so that tile is now hers alone. Her **Ocean** card **explores**: she picks an empty space beside her civilization, checks it touches at least two tiles already on the map (it touches three), and lays the Ocean tile from the supply.
- **Ada** (2 cards, one of them set aside). She keeps the **6 of Plains** and sets the 5 aside — the only Plains in reach is her own homeland, and a second unit there is worth more than a coin. She **settles** the 6 on it, Plains holding three. The 5 goes to the shared pile and pays her **1 gold**: the cost of matching Bex and losing.
- **Cy** (1 card). He has already taken **1 gold** for ranking last. The card itself he also cashes, for a second gold: nothing on the map is worth reaching for yet, and he is banking toward an upgrade.

Each also had **one free move** — the Tribe stride — but with one or two units standing exactly where they want them, nobody moved. Notice what did *not* happen: no Forest or Ocean tile existed to settle on, so the only way to use those suits was to build the ground first. To finish the round they check the end triggers — no one has placed their last unit and no suit deck is empty, so play continues. No one emptied a whole tier, so meld limits stay at 2, nobody has claimed an ascension coin, and no food is due; that only comes when a hand recycles. **Bex leads the next round**.

### WHAT JUST HAPPENED

One meld did two jobs for each player: it fought for the trick, then became the budget they spent on the map. Bex's 16 against Ada's 11 won her both initiative and a full turn; Cy's cautious single let him hoard gold instead. That trade — tempo now against resources later — is the whole game in miniature.

## 11 End of the game

The end is triggered as soon as either:



- a player places the **last unit** from their reserve onto the map, or
- the **market thins to a single layer** — the upgrade deck is empty and no grid position has a card buried under another. While the deck lasts every research deepens the market; once it is dry the market can only be eaten down, and its last layer is the last of the ideas.

Finish the current round, then play **one more full round**. Then score.

SCORE

|             |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Population  | 1 point per unit you have on the map.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| Victory row | <b>1 point per card</b> in the row — always, however many you hold. <i>Then, in addition</i> , arrange them in rank order <b>pushed to the right</b> of five slots: if you hold three or more, also score the <b>rank in the centre slot</b> . A full row of five therefore scores 5 plus its middle rank.                                                                                                                                                       |
| Dominance   | 3 points for each terrain type where you hold the <b>largest connected stretch</b> of it. Count only tiles of that terrain that <b>you have units on</b> , and that touch each other; your biggest such group is your stretch. Scattered holdings do not add up — a stack of five units on one tile is a stretch of <b>one</b> . If two players are level, the one with <b>more units on that terrain</b> takes it. A terrain nobody occupies scores for nobody. |

Three cards — 3 + centre slot 3 = 6

3

3

9

9

15

15

Five cards — 5 + centre slot 11 = 16

3

3

7

7

11

11

14

14

18

18

The empty slots sit on the left, so the centre slot only reaches your true middle card once all five are filled. A half-full row scores a lower card — and slipping a low card in can push your centre down. Every card is also worth a point in its own right, so spending one is never free.

| YOUR VICTORY ROW           | LAID OUT IN FIVE SLOTS | SCORES      |
|----------------------------|------------------------|-------------|
| 2 cards — 9, 17            | ... 9 17               | 2           |
| 3 cards — 6, 9, 17         | .. 6 9 17              | 3 + 6 = 9   |
| 4 cards — 6, 9, 14, 17     | · 6 9 14 17            | 4 + 9 = 13  |
| 5 cards — 6, 9, 14, 16, 17 | 6 9 14 16 17           | 5 + 14 = 19 |

The point per card is always there — with fewer than three cards it is *all* you score, which is why the third card is where the row starts paying properly and the fifth is where it pays best.

Most points wins. Gold breaks a tie.

#### BEYOND THE BASE GAME

Two optional layers deepen scoring once the base game is familiar, each in its own booklet: **shared map objectives** — pattern cards like rivers, silk roads and mountain ranges that everyone can score — and **personal objectives**, secret goals held from the start. Add them one at a time, not for your first game or two.

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## Glossary

### Meld

The cards you play in one round — one to your meld limit. It competes for the trick, then each of its cards is spent on the map or cashed for gold.

### Cell

The single hex a card acts on — a tile or empty space in your reach, matching the card's suit.

### Reach

Where your cards may act: any tile you occupy, or any tile or empty space adjacent to one you occupy (§06).

### Civilization

All your units on the map, and the tiles they stand on.

### Tier

One of the five rows of your reserve — Tribe, Settlement, Kingdom, Empire, Civilization. Your *current tier* is the topmost one still holding units; it prints your meld limit, your free moves, your food slots and your rank cap.

### Ascension

Reaching a tier for the first time. Take the coins printed on that tier: 1, 2, 3, 4 as you climb. Once only (§04).

### Shared pile

The face-down stack of cards *set aside* by melds that matched the winner's count and lost. You refill your hand from it (§09).

### Set aside

The card you give up for matching the trick winner's card count and losing. You choose which of your played cards it is; it pays you 1 gold instead of acting on the map, and goes to the shared pile (§04).

### Free moves

Your band's allowance of unit movement each map phase — by land across your own network, or by sea across open Ocean. Never an attack (§07).

### Food slots

The coin spaces on your current band. What stands there when your hand recycles is what your people eat (§09).

### Recycle

The moment your hand empties: you feed your population, then take your personal discard back as your new hand (§09).

## Victory row

The five slots on your board holding retired cards. They score at the end — or can each be spent once for an effect, and then are gone.

# Quick reference

## Reserve bands

Units sit in tiers of 2 / 3 / 5 / 5 / 5, emptied top-down. **Tribe** melds 2, 1 move, food free, cap 12. **Settlement** 3, 2, food 1, cap 14. **Kingdom** 4, 3, food 2, cap 16. **Empire** 5, 4, food 3, cap 18. **Civilization** 6, 5, food 4, cap 20. Read them off your current tier only — food is **not** cumulative, eaten each time your hand recycles. Reaching a tier pays its ascension coins once: 1 / 2 / 3 / 4. Placing your last unit ends the game.

## Round

Declare A effects blind → leader plays a meld → everyone plays a meld → highest total wins, then most cards, then highest card, then earliest played (never a tie) → spend melds in initiative order. The winner spends every card. Anyone who **matched** the winner's count and lost sets one played card aside: 1 gold, and it goes to the shared pile. Last place takes 1 gold.

## Melds — one rule

Any cards whose ranks form an **unbroken run**. Duplicates of any rank are free; suits are irrelevant. One card is always legal. 2 ✓ · 2-2 ✓ · 2-3 ✓ · 2-3-3-4-4 ✓ · **2-2-4-4** ✗ (no 3). Limit by tier: 2 / 3 / 4 / 5 / 6.

## Each card of your meld

ONE of: Settle a unit · Explore a tile · Attack (pay the terrain price) · Take 1 gold. Any order; each card resolves on the map as the last one left it.

Reach: a tile you occupy or adjacent to one you occupy. Suit matches terrain. No units on the map? Act anywhere.

The winner spends every card, and so does anyone who played FEWER. Anyone who MATCHED the winner's count and lost sets one played card aside —

## Terrain

|          |                          |
|----------|--------------------------|
| Plains   | holds 3                  |
| Ocean    | holds 1 · sea roads      |
| Forest   | holds 2 · attack costs 1 |
| Mountain | holds 1 · attack costs 2 |

## Exploring

A new tile must touch **at least two** tiles already on the map, in your reach, matching the card's suit. The supply is open; if that terrain has run out, the card takes gold.

## Free actions, your turn

**Moves** (tier number, 1–5): by land across your own connected units onto a free adjacent tile, or by sea across unoccupied Ocean. Never an attack. · **Water advantage**: your first sea move each turn lets you explore one free tile of ANY terrain, anywhere on the map (touch-two applies; **reach does not**). · **Reallocate gold** freely between reserve, food slots and fortifications; research spending is one-way. · **One victory card on B** per turn.

## Fortifying

1 gold on one of your units: the next attack takes the gold instead of the unit. One per unit, placed on your own turn only, lost when the unit is disturbed.

## Gold

1 per cashed card · ascension coins 1/2/3/4, once each · 1 for ranking last · pay 1 to research · pay 1 to fortify · pay 1–2 *per card* to attack Forest or Mountain · your tier's food (0/1/2/3/4, not cumulative) is eaten

1 gold, and the card goes face down to the shared pile. The meld that ranked LAST takes 1 gold.

when your hand recycles — short slots starve units off the map.

## Research — up to twice per turn

Draw the top upgrade card onto the position showing the **highest rank**, covering it (leftmost breaks a tie; nobody chooses) → retire the **lowest-ranked card in your hand** to your victory row → pay → take any visible card **at or below your tier's rank cap** (12/14/16/18/20, +2 a tier) → refill empty positions. The **first research of your turn costs 1 gold, the second costs 2**. No cards in hand, no research this turn.

## Refilling your hand

Hand empty: **at once, mid-turn** — feed, take back your discard, then draw from the **shared pile** up to ten. Carry on with the turn.

## Victory-card effects

Spend a victory card for ONE of: **A** add its rank to your meld's total this trick (higher bands win ties) · **B** found a colony — new tiles + units + fortifications from the GENERAL SUPPLY, once per turn · **C** take 2–5 gold. A is declared **blind, before any meld is played**; B in your own map phase; C at any moment. The card leaves the game.

## Scoring

Units on the map + 1 per card in your victory row + the centre-slot rank of that row once it holds three or more + 3 per terrain for the **largest connected stretch** you occupy, level broken by units on that terrain. Gold breaks ties on the final score.